

YADAV MIGHT Akhilesh at an SP Vijay Rath rally in Mainpuri, Dec. '21

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ASSEMBLY POLLS 2022

UTTAR PRADESH

THE Y-AXIS: Eight Squares on the Chessboard

The 'Yadav belt' in western UP is a traditional Samajwadi fortress. Can the party regain the ground it lost in 2017 or will the BJP spring another surprise?

BY ASHISH MISRA

The political mobility of caste groups—real and potential, en bloc or piecemeal—defines elections in Uttar Pradesh. All the knife-edge speculation this time has tended to focus on two geographical extremes: the western provinces, mostly because of Jat disaffection with the BJP, or Poorvanchal, where a complex play of algorithms could swing the game any which way. Everywhere, the focus has been on non-Yadav castes—OBC or otherwise. That presumes the Yadav element in the mix is a constant rather than a variable. But the Samajwadi Party has reasons to harbour a creeping disquiet on that point. So, the question for the BJP's chief rival may well be: will the centre hold?

A terrestrial trawl through the 'Yadav belt' of central UP gives us a more fine-grained picture of the fascinating caste catalysis on the ground. Zero in on a physical border: Jain Inter College, in Mainpuri district, is where the Karhal assembly seat starts. Just 6 km south of it is Saifai, ancestral village of SP founder Mulayam Singh Yadav, which falls in Etawah. In 1963, Mulayam started working here as an assistant teacher (he was promoted as lecturer in the department of political science in 1974, though by then he was already into his second term as an MLA). There is a festive mood at the college. Akhilesh Yadav, Mulayam's son and national president of SP, is contesting from Karhal. Before filing his nomination on January 31, the former chief minister had visited and taken the blessings of the teachers. He even promised to upgrade it to a university if the SP wins.

Akhilesh is contesting for the first time from Karhal, part of Mulayam's parliamentary constituency, Mainpuri. The area is an SP fortress; in the six assembly polls held since the party was formed in 1992, it has won the seat five times. Even during the BJP wave in 2017, Karhal stayed true to the SP. It wasn't the same in the eight districts around Mainpuri-Etawah—known as the "Yadav belt" for the sway the community has in the region—which witnessed the SP's worst performance since its formation (see *BJP's Rise...*). These have a total of 28 seats; in 2012, the SP won 26 of these seats but in 2017 they were left with six.

In that sense, it's a strategic move for Akhilesh to contest from Karhal: an attempt to reconsolidate. Padma Tripathi, head of the department of economics at K.K. PG College, Etawah (incidentally Mulayam's alma mater), says, "Saifai is the focal point of politics in many districts here, including Mainpuri, Firozabad and Auraiya. Yadavs are dominant in every seat here. The internal disputes in the Mulayam family clearly affected the results in 2017." By contesting from Karhal, Akhilesh hopes to exude a